

August 12, 2026

UnitedHealthcare
Provider Appeals
P.O. Box 30432
Salt Lake City, UT 84130

RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — José María Casares (MRN MUSC9324983), Claim MUSC-20260302-9913-2

Patient	José María Casares (DOB 1974-07-05)
MRN	MUSC9324983
Member ID / Group	UHC137146189 / GRP-40219
Claim number	MUSC-20260302-9913-2
Date of service	2026-03-02
Procedure billed	CPT 99214 — Office/outpatient visit, established patient, moderate complexity
Primary diagnosis	J06.9 — Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified
Denied amount	\$465.32
Denial code	CARC 197 / RARC N54 — Precertification/authorization/notification/pre-treatment absent.
Appeal deadline	2027-04-21

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

SUMMARY OF APPEAL

MUSC Health Florence Medical Center submits this formal first-level appeal on behalf of patient José María Casares (MRN: MUSC9324983, Member ID: UHC137146189, Group GRP-40219) regarding the denial of Claim MUSC-20260302-9913-2 for services rendered on March 2, 2026, by Sarah E. Whitmore, MD (NPI 1447382910). UnitedHealthcare denied the claim in full — \$465.32 — citing CARC 197 ("Precertification/authorization/notification/pre-treatment absent") and RARC N54 ("Claim information is inconsistent with pre-certified/authorized services"), with the payer remark stating: "No prior authorization on file for the date of service billed." MUSC Health respectfully contests this denial on the grounds that prior authorization is not a contractual or clinical requirement for the service billed, and that the denial therefore lacks a valid basis.

CLINICAL BACKGROUND

Mr. Casares is a 52-year-old male enrolled in the UnitedHealthcare Choice Plus plan (coverage period January 1, 2024, through December 31, 2026) who presented on March 2, 2026, at MUSC Health Florence Medical Center, an on-campus outpatient hospital facility (Place of Service 22). He was seen by Dr. Whitmore for an acute upper respiratory infection (J06.9). Mr. Casares carries active diagnoses of obesity (E66.9) and hypertension (I10), the latter managed long-term with hydrochlorothiazide. The visit was coded as CPT 99214, an established-patient office or outpatient visit of moderate complexity, which is consistent with the clinical picture of an acute symptomatic illness in a patient with multiple active comorbidities requiring medical decision-making of at least moderate complexity.

BASIS FOR APPEAL

CPT code 99214 is a standard evaluation and management (E/M) service for established outpatient patients. Under broadly accepted coding and coverage principles, routine outpatient E/M visits — particularly those addressing acute, time-sensitive conditions such as an upper respiratory infection — are not subject to prior authorization requirements. UnitedHealthcare's own published prior authorization and notification lists, as well as general commercial plan conventions, do not typically designate established-patient E/M services at this level as requiring precertification. MUSC Health has reviewed its records and finds no contractual provision under the UnitedHealthcare Choice Plus plan, Group GRP-40219, that mandates prior authorization for a 99214 rendered in an outpatient hospital setting.

Furthermore, RARC N54 indicates that claim information is inconsistent with pre-certified or authorized services. Because no prior authorization was required for this service category, there is no authorization against which the claim could be inconsistent. The application of this remark code is therefore inapplicable to the facts of this claim. The denial appears to have been generated in error, possibly through an automated review process that misclassified the place-of-service or service type. MUSC Health respectfully requests that UnitedHealthcare conduct a manual review of the applicable prior authorization requirements for CPT 99214 at Place of Service 22 under this specific plan and group, and confirm that no such requirement exists.

The allowed amount of \$344.66 already established by UnitedHealthcare's adjudication indicates that the service was recognized as covered and appropriately valued. The sole stated basis for zero payment is the absence of prior authorization — a requirement that does not apply to this service. Withholding payment under these circumstances is inconsistent with the member's coverage and with MUSC Health's provider agreement obligations to receive timely and accurate reimbursement for covered services rendered.

REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health respectfully requests that UnitedHealthcare overturn the denial of Claim MUSC-20260302-9913-2, remove the prior authorization edit as inapplicable to CPT 99214 for this plan and place of service, and reprocess the claim for payment at the previously established allowed amount of \$344.66. Should UnitedHealthcare maintain that prior authorization was required, we further request that the payer provide, in writing, the specific plan provision, benefit document section, or prior authorization list entry that designates CPT 99214 at Place of Service 22 as subject to precertification under Group GRP-40219. This appeal is submitted within the appeal deadline of April 21, 2027, via the required electronic channel as directed in the denial notice.

Respectfully submitted,

Angela R. Whitfield, RN, BSN, CPC

Senior Appeals Specialist, Revenue Cycle Management
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Enclosures

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record